

It Didn't Rain

A two-minute customer story. Deadpan testimonial, filmed in Sedgemoor village hall and the field behind it.

The principle. A man who has never written a line of code asks Code Overlord where to put the stalls at the village fete, and its agents build him an app. He calls it Bunthorne, and he keeps going back to have it wired into one more real thing: the tannoy, a board in the hall window, the milk order. The fete takes eight times what it took the year it rained, and by the end Bunthorne runs the day with his laptop shut at home.

Why it is funny. Everything he asks for arrives exactly as asked, and the fete gets better on the strength of it. Then he goes back one last time, with the one question nobody in an English village has ever been able to answer, and Bunthorne answers it.

"How long had you waited to chair the fete?"

"Twenty-eight years."

"And your first one?"

"It rained. Six hundred and forty in the tin."

"Is that a lot?"

"It's a tank of oil."

The hall that winter: Barbara, who does the teas, in her coat.

Barbara: "That's wholly cold in here."

Alan: "She said it wasn't my fault." A pause. "In front of everybody." A beat. "All I wanted was a fete that paid for the oil. So I asked Code Overlord where the stalls should go."

Forty windows open under his question.

"I'd never written a line of anything. By Thursday the field was in a computer. I called it Bunthorne."

Ron does the plants, and hates his pitch.

"So you moved Ron?"

"You can't move Ron. It moved the way out."

Then he had Code Overlord put Bunthorne on the tannoy. It writes the announcements off ten years of fetes, and a board in the hall window clacks them to the lane. That July, five thousand two hundred in the tin, against six hundred and forty.

"Where from?"

"They had to walk past Ron." A pause. "Barbara was out of milk by two. So I had Code Overlord give Bunthorne a rule. Never run out."

Bunthorne orders the milk now, every hour: whatever that hour of a July fete has ever drunk.

Barbara: "You won't never beat that, Alan."

That night he had Code Overlord teach Bunthorne the weather.

Alan, typing: "Which day would it never rain on?"

On screen, seven days, all ticked. The cursor rests on Saturday a long time. The tick comes off.

"What was that?"

"Took the Saturdays out."

"All of them?"

"There's only fifty-two."

"But the fete's on a Saturday."

"It's a fete."

On screen: "Wednesday 14 March 2029. Chance of rain: 0.4%." Underneath, small: bunthorne.com.

Barbara: "That's a school day."

Alan: "Nought point four."

March. Four degrees. SUMMER FETE, laminated, at the gate. Thirty-seven empty trestles. Keith, who does the car park, in hi-vis in an empty one. On the bouncy castle his grandson, eight, has it to himself: the best morning of his life.

Bunthorne, on the tannoy: "The bouncy castle is very busy. Please wait at the side."

The board clacks it out to the lane.

At twelve, a milk van: everything twelve o'clock on a July Saturday has ever drunk. At one, two vans. At two, a lorry.

Driver, eyeing the field: "Am I early?"

Keith: "No, bor."

Boy: "Grandad, can I come off now?"

Keith: "No. Stay on a bit longer."

"Why can't he come off?"

Alan: "It's on the board. It's got to look busy."

By three, crates have walled Barbara into the tea hut.

Barbara: "Two thousand pints. I've done nine teas."

Alan: "I gave it a rule. It hasn't run out. How many now, Keith?"

Keith: "Eleven, bor. Two of them are drivers."

At four, another lorry. Keith waves it in with one hand. The other is through the castle netting, holding a cup of milk to his grandson, who lies face down and only moves when the blower comes on.

Laptop at home, shut. Alan counts the tin.

"Forty-one pounds, against five thousand two hundred last July. It's a record for a Wednesday."

"And the milk?"

"Eleven hundred pound. We're all right for milk."

The castle goes down. The boy comes off it like a man off a ship.

Boy: "Thank you for having me."

Alan: "You come again." To camera: "Nought point four per cent, Bunthorne said." A beat. "That didn't rain. Code Overlord's not been wrong yet."

Card. Nothing after it.

What a Code Overlord user sees, and nobody else does. The one sentence he typed, and forty windows opening under it. A schedule called Fete, every hour on the day: "Write the next announcement off the last ten years. Keep it short." A rule called Milk: "Never run out." And the laptop at home and shut, while the tannoy, the board and the milk all keep going without it.

Accent. The whole cast is strong Norfolk, Norwich and the villages. Cast and voice it that way without exception, and never spell it: the Norfolk is in the grammar and the word order, which is how the lines are written. Alan is the least marked person in it, because twenty-eight years of committee minutes have got into his English. The Norfolk "that" for "it" belongs to two people only: Barbara, first thing, and Alan, to camera, last thing.

Condensed from a longer version that went through two comedians' panels; the long version is kept.

Three things to decide. Runtime: just under 600 words of film, under 300 of them spoken, about two minutes on screen. Shoot it as written. Whether the four o'clock lorry and the boy being fed milk through the netting are one shot: yes, one shot, Keith in the middle of both. Whether the interviewer is ever seen: no, only heard.